

Selection from Joanna Kadish "Stupidity" Deconstructed

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CONSTRUCTING/DECONSTRUCTING: BUILDING/HIRING

For the capitalist system to continue ruthlessly grinding on (or for the capitalist system to "succeed," as you would say) those of us bred for stupid and/or dangerous work must believe we're not as smart as the people who boss us around. It's critical. Capitalism needs simple explanations about why poor people with lousy jobs take orders from men in suits. Lack of brains fits the bill. (So does the lie that rich people work harder. I'll tackle that in another essay.) Any noticeable class divisions stem from difference in intellectual capacity. Connected to this is the touting of "American ingenuity" as the doorway to upward mobility. It's as untrue as the existence of a whole class of stupid people, but if enough people believe it—even partially believe it—this idea will reinforce and strengthen capitalism. After all, if we believe brains lead to success, we'll blame ourselves for not getting ahead. Personal failure, not systemic oppression, explains why we're going nowhere so very fast.

I grew up learning the bulk of the population in our small general motors city—that is, workers—was stupid. Dumb, brutish, boring, close to animals. Did I believe it? In some ways, I knew people in my family had brains and the bosses didn't. My extended family joked about it frequently. But just as frequently, they indicated they believed it. And at deep levels, I internalized the lie and lived with it for years. It impacted my thoughts, decisions, and actions, and surfaced resoundingly when I entered university. The smugness and certainty with which upper-middle-class people paraded their brain cells jarred me; for a time I was taken in by this, and it contrasted so sharply with my inability to speak, let alone parade, that I felt

I really must be stupid. Thankfully, that didn't last long. *Who knows what will happen if we realize that we're not so stupid and you're not so smart? Maybe you'll lose privileges and status. Maybe you'll have to clean up your own messes. Maybe we'll find fulfilling work and the drudge work will be shared equally. Maybe we'll remove your feet from our necks.*

Of course, I didn't feel stupid at university only because of constructions concerning stupid workers. That coupled with an unfamiliar upper-middle-class world made me feel stupid. I didn't know any of the middle-class/upper-middle-class reference points and contexts, ranging from GRE's and LSAT's to Ph.D.'s and post-doc fellowships. I couldn't swish around with the entitlement of privileged students; I crept. I liked janitors more than professors; more to the point, I identified with janitors, not professors.

Language proved crucially important in opening a door into clarity, awareness, and class pride. It happened this way: I grew up around people who built things—houses, additions on houses, large buildings. They talked about it by saying, "I built that." This meant they planned and designed something, then picked up a hammer, nails, and saw, and began constructing.

University professors used this same phrase, often when discussing summer homes. They said authoritatively, "I built that." I knew what it meant to build something and I thought they meant they must have built their summer home. But they didn't look like they knew anything about construction work. I felt confused. I was astounded when I stumbled across the translation. "I built this" really meant "I hired some of you to build this for me."

So. Privileged people misuse language in ways that distort meanings of commonplace, easy-to-understand words like "build." This told me something. Then I read articles focusing on class, usually written by university professors. I looked forward to these, because I needed to develop my class analysis and thought these articles would help. But again disappointment and shame resulted. I didn't understand most of what I read. Abstract and impersonal, these essays stood three times removed from concrete reality of working-class life.

After confusion and shame, another door opened. If they misused a simple word like build, how could I trust them? If their articles used weird words like "proletariat" and showed they didn't know the first thing about us, maybe they weren't quite so smart. *Maybe we weren't quite so stupid.*

My hunch solidified after examining academic attraction to and use of postmodern theory and language. This horrible mix of distorted language and casual appropriation of our ideas allowed me once and for all to dismiss the ideology about stupid workers. As far as I can tell, postmodern theoreticians say nothing new, but their inaccessible language makes it appear as though they do. For example, they're fascinated with the notion that multiple realities exist in society, and they've written and theorized extensively about this.

Puh-lease. Everybody in my neighborhood, including the mechanics who had to sniff carbon monoxide in tiny, enclosed garages all day long, grasped that idea with no problem. We lived it. We had our reality, the bosses had theirs, and we understood them both. Theorists like W. E. B. Du Bois wrote about double consciousness—whereby African Americans understand their reality and white people's—at the turn of this century. But I've never seen postmodernists attribute these ideas to the people of color and/or working-class people who've lived and understood them for centuries. Instead, postmodernists steal these ideas and dress them up in language so inaccessible only a tiny, elite group can discuss them.

We need to ask, and begin answering, hard, practical questions. Who defines smart and stupid, and why? Who misuses language, and for whose benefit? Who writes theory, and why? Who goes to university, and why? Who does the academy serve? Can universities be transformed into places where everyone is welcomed and respected?

In this country, the first institutions of higher learning were trade or agricultural schools and theological centers, with liberal arts colleges and medical schools following. Around the turn of this century, with the establishment of standardization and class-biased guidelines, universities took on the task of

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serving middle- and upper-class white men. That group enjoyed peace and quiet for several decades, until the rest of us began banging on the door. Grudgingly, after years and years of hard work, little chinks appeared in those thick, stone doors. *The doors we built, with our hands. The doors we couldn't walk through.* The misfits demanded entrance: Africans, Asians, Natives, Arabs, Latinos, women, queers, even welfare mothers. Even the sons and daughters of factory workers and miners and janitors. What's a rich white man to do? The stress must be unbelievable. Poor guys.

Capitalism exists as a human construct, not a natural or innate system. We've been steeped in lies about its inevitability, and it seems to take on its own life as its institutions reinforce each other and the system. But it *is* a human construct, carefully set up to keep a small number of people stretched out comfortably along the backs of the rest of us. Remember: human constructs can be destroyed.

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At 3:00 P.M., construction workers on the University of Minnesota campus finish up. Privileged university students grumble about what an easy job these guys have and how early they're leaving. They have no idea these workers arrived at 6:00 or 7:00 in the morning. They don't know how a body feels after eight hours of physical labor. They don't care.

As for me, I just watch the workers go by and feel many things. I feel at home, because these men look so familiar, from their flannel shirts, jeans, and work-boots down to lunch pails and thermoses, cigarettes, and hard hats. I feel comfortable, because I like being around them. *These are my people. And we're not stupid.* I feel angry, because I know how students and professors perceive these workers. Because I know some of these workers believe the lies about who's stupid and who's smart, who has the right to think and study here and who has the right to build and clean here.

But I am clear. *I'm working-class. I'm smart. Just like the people I grew up with.* We know how to screw the system, we know how to take care of ourselves and survive when the odds are against us. We cook tasty meals with one onion, build our own stereo speakers, cut precisely-fitting pieces of wood for porches, know how to wire our houses and sew clothes, we like to read and think and talk to each other. We make music and art and tell stories. We know how to work cooperatively and we know how to give, generously, both hands open.

I've figured out I belong in the university. Not just when they need a janitor, or a cook, or a construction worker. But when I want to go. If I choose to study there, I won't let anyone make me feel stupid; I'll remember why it's so important they try. I won't let them turn me into an assimilationist, a fraud, a middle-class-identified polite girl who's grateful for all the help these nice rich people offer. I'll stay true to my roots. I'll use my brains, and my hands, to take this system apart. I'll use my brains, and my hands, to get your feet off my neck.